TEXAS

The Lone Star State



San Antonio in the 1880s was a city caught between two worlds—part Mexican, part American, part frontier, and entirely its own thing. The air along Military Plaza smelled of charcoal smoke and cumin long before sundown, when the women the city would come to call the Chili Queens set up their wooden tables, iron pots, and lanterns in the open square and began feeding anyone who wandered close enough to follow their nose.

The Chili Queens were almost entirely Mexican and Mexican-American women who had been working the plazas of San Antonio since at least the 1860s. They hauled their pots from home each evening, already heavy with a slowly built stew of beef, dried chiles, and spices that had been simmering for hours before the first customer arrived. The dish they served had deep roots in the cooking of northern Mexico—particularly the states of Coahuila and Nuevo León, where dried chile peppers were ground with wild oregano, cumin, and garlic and worked into preserved meat for long cattle drives and military expeditions across the harsh Chihuahuan Desert. It was practical food born from scarcity, designed to travel and sustain, built on the understanding that dried chiles carried heat, depth, and nutrition in a way that nothing else could.

What the Chili Queens brought to Military Plaza and later to Haymarket Plaza was that same tradition, refined by generations of hands and adapted to the ingredients available in a booming Texas border city. Cowboys, soldiers, traders, and travelers—men passing through San Antonio on their way somewhere else—sat down at those lantern-lit tables and ate something they would spend the rest of their lives trying to find again. Tourists arriving by rail from the East reported the experience in letters and newspaper columns, and the reputation of San Antonio's chili spread well beyond Texas.

By the time the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition in Chicago opened a "San Antonio Chili Stand," the dish had already crossed into American culinary mythology. Texas declared it the official state dish in 1977, though anyone who grew up near the Rio Grande would tell you it never needed an official declaration—it had always belonged to the land, the people, and the fire underneath the pot.

That fire is yours to tend now. This is a dish that rewards patience and generosity with spice—one that fills a kitchen with the kind of smell that draws people in from other rooms. Made well, a bowl of chili con carne is less a recipe than an inheritance, rich, smoky, and deeply satisfying in the way that only food with a long history behind it can be.

CHILI CON CARNE

In every slow-simmered pot of Texas chili, patience and fire conspire to turn humble ingredients into something legendary.

Yield: 6–8 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 3 lb. beef chuck, trimmed and cut into ½-inch cubes
- 3 Tbsp vegetable oil or bacon drippings
- 2 medium onions, chopped
- 4 cloves garlic, minced
- 1–2 fresh jalapeños, minced (optional, for extra heat)
- 3 Tbsp chili powder (preferably ancho or Texas-style blend)
- 1 Tbsp ground cumin
- 2 tsp smoked paprika
- 1 tsp dried oregano (Mexican oregano preferred)
- 1 tsp salt, plus more to taste
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 2 Tbsp tomato paste (optional, for color and body)
- 3 cups beef broth or stock
- 1 Tbsp masa harina, for thickening
- Chopped onions, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Brown the beef*: Heat oil in a large Dutch oven or heavy pot over medium-high heat. Add beef in batches, browning on all sides. Remove and set aside.
2. *Sauté aromatics*: In the same pot, add onions and cook until softened, 5 minutes. Stir in garlic and jalapeños; cook 1 minute more.
3. *Build flavor*: Stir in chili powder, cumin, paprika, oregano, salt, and black pepper. Toast the spices for 30 seconds to release their aroma.
4. *Add liquid and simmer*: Return beef to the pot. Add tomato paste (if using) and broth. Stir well, bring to a simmer, then reduce heat to low. Cover and cook gently for 1½–2 hours, stirring occasionally, until the beef is tender and the flavors meld.
5. *Thicken and finish*: Stir masa harina into a few Tbsp of warm water, then mix into the chili. Simmer 10 minutes more to thicken. Adjust seasoning to taste.
6. *Serve*: Ladle into bowls and top with chopped onion.

